

Response Letter with Annotations

Citation (APA format, using Zotero or other bibliography software)

Guess, A. M. (2021). (Almost) everything in moderation: new evidence on Americans' online media diets. *American Journal of Political Science*, 65(4), 1007-1022.

Annotations

1. Purposes

a. Motivation (one-sentence summary)

The motivation of this study is to explore whether selective exposure to political news exists on the internet by analyzing and comparing political news consumption ideological slant across different political groups, using survey data and news consumption data collected through passive metering technologies.

b. Specific Rationale (several bullet points)

- Exposure to competing viewpoints is a critical precondition for democratic discourse and deliberation.
- Increased consumption of online news highlights the significance of studying this issue in the internet context.
- Existing scholarship shows conflicting findings: greater homogeneity or greater diversity?

c. Research Questions and/or Hypotheses

- This study is mainly exploratory and inductive, and there are no explicit hypotheses. The author primarily explores:
 - (1) whether people's online media diets differ by partisanship;
 - (2) whether different periods show similar patterns (2015 and 2016, before the presidential election);
 - (3) whether different news sources influence selective exposure. For example, whether web portals and news aggregators lead to more diverse consumption.
 - Identify IV, DV, mediator, moderator
- IV: partisan affiliation(democrat, republican, independent)
- Moderator: web portals(inclusion/exclusion)
- DV: individual media diet slant

Note: this may not apply in this study because there are no explicit hypotheses

- Identify specific relationships among variables

2. Method

a. Research Design

- Experiment: conditions, manipulations, etc.
- Survey: cross-sectional, longitudinal, etc.
- Content analysis: data source, etc.
- ...

The study used a combination of methods, including individual-level web and mobile consumption data from two periods (February 27 to March 18, 2015, and October 7 to 31, 2016), surveys, and supervised text classification of millions of web pages.

- Survey data: Surveys were collected by YouGov Pulse.
- Passive metering data: Participants who installed the Wakoopa software, after providing consent, sent their web visit data to YouGov.
- Classification of web pages: The text of URLs in the Pulse data was scraped, and a penalized logistic regression model was applied to classify whether a page was political or non-political news.

b. Sample (representative sample?)

The 2015 data included N= 1392 respondents and 6319441 visits. Raking weights were used for the 2015 sample. By taking to the population marginal distributions of age, gender, race, region, and party identification, representativeness was increased.

The 2016 data covered 16984969 visits (N=2512 respondents). The 2016 data applied supplied sample-matching weights.

c. Measures

- Ideological slant of online media source: Alignment scores produced by Bakshy, Messing, and Adamic (2015) based on the averaged self-reported ideology of users who have **shared** pages from that domain on Facebook.
- Classification of political news: use a penalized logistic regression model trained on text features of scraped articles to dichotomize news URLs as politics-related or not.
- Individual ideological(media diet) lean: the average of the alignment scores for domains associated with an individual's web visits from left-leaning or right-leaning sites in the Pulse data.

d. Analysis

- Distribution of average media diets by party
- Descriptive summaries of medians, means, SDs
- Overlapping coefficients: the shared area of two curves by two parties (0= complete overlap, 1= no overlap, 0.5 is chosen as a standard for a meaningfully shared informational environment)
- Simple linear regression of media slant on individual-level characteristics
- Distribution of news sites visit slant
- Linking YouGov survey data to voter turnout data from TargetSmart

3. Results and Conclusions

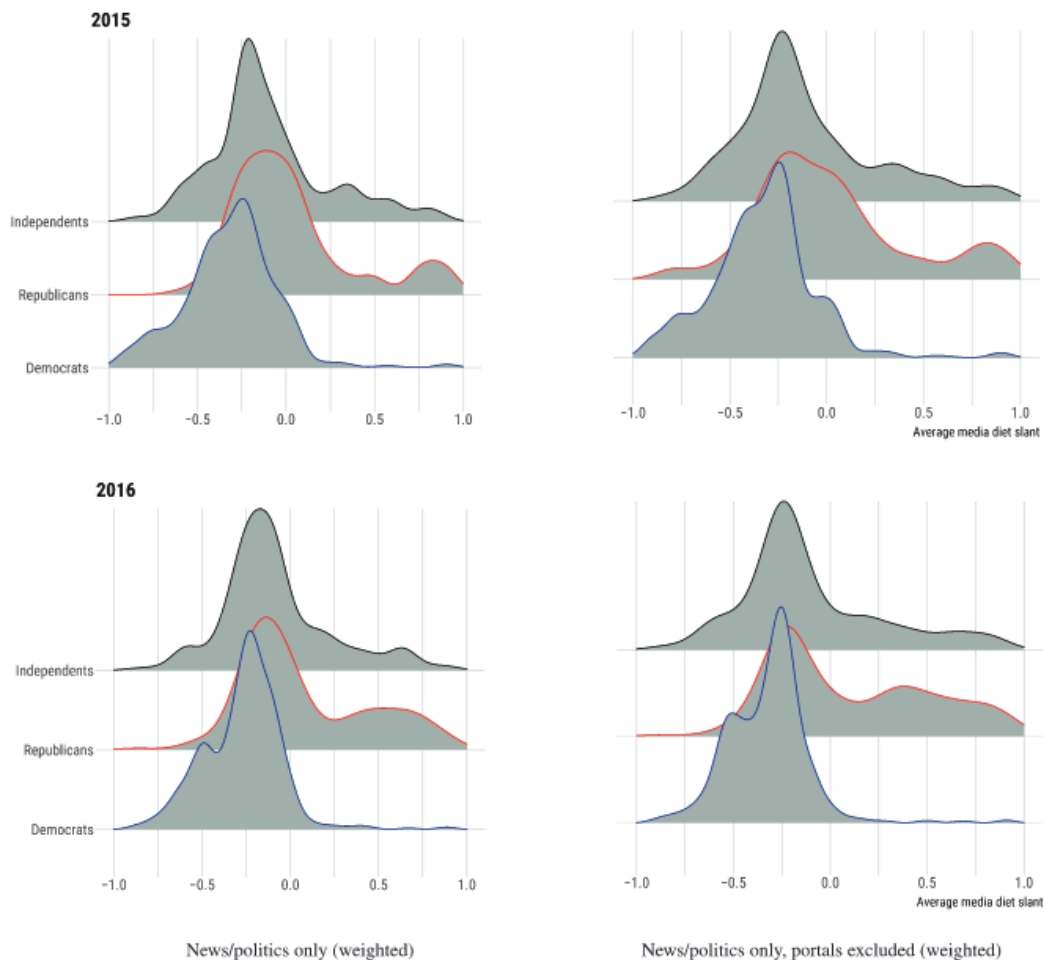
a. Answers to RQs and Hypotheses

- Moderation in media diets regardless of partisan affiliation: Whether Democrat, Republican, or independent, most individuals' media diets cluster around the center of the ideological spectrum.
- Beyond baseline overlap between democrats and republicans in media diets.
- A small subset of Republican respondents have consistently conservative media diets.
- The inclusion of portals (and major mainstream news sites) serves to anchor the distributions closer to the center of the ideological spectrum

- Comparison between 2015 and 2016: The 2015 evidence is more consistent with the hypothesis that the internet facilitates exposure to cross-cutting information, reflected by the larger overlapping coefficients.
- Mobile data strikingly show a broader overlap (overlap coefficient = 0.59), contrary to the speculation that evolution of news consumption practices might be a driver of online selective exposure
- There is a correlation between partisan affiliation and media consumption, but it is reasonably modest (supported by linear regression analysis).
- Traffic to the most partisan websites comes from a small proportion of respondents (a subgroup of republicans consume large quantities of conservative). The preponderance of the content encountered is ideologically moderate, and most people are not habitual partisan news consumers
- When linked with voter turnout from TargetSmart. The results show that turnout was markedly higher among those with the most homogeneously partisan media consumption habits.

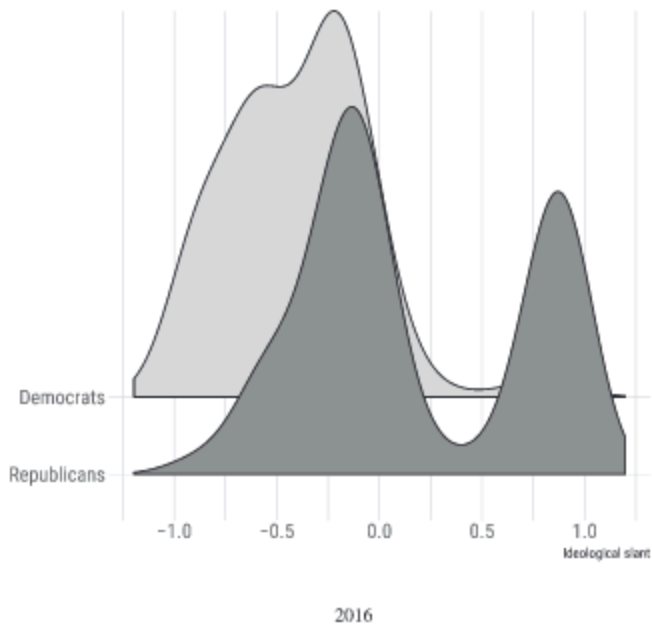
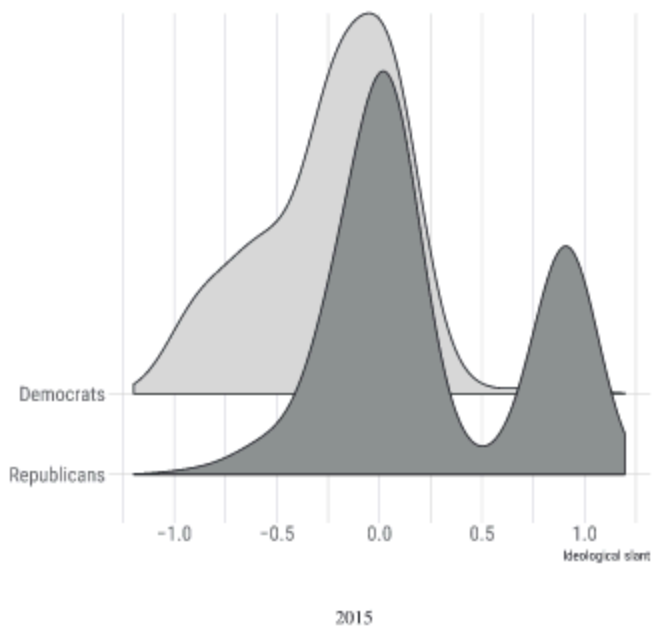
b. Include Key Figures/Tables

FIGURE 1 Americans' Online Media Diets by Partisanship



Note: Top: Distribution of the slant of respondents' online media diets, Feb. 27-March 19, 2015. Bottom: Distribution of online media diet slant, Oct. 7-31, 2016.

FIGURE 2 Slant of Site Visits by Respondent Partisanship



Note: Site ideological slant on the x-axis is measured as the average self-reported ideological placement of Facebook users who share “hard news” articles from a given domain. Only visits from pages classified as related to news/politics are included.

- c. Authors' Conclusions
- Most news consumers are not partisan in the sources they use to learn about politics.

- People who do regularly read political news and rely on partisan sources to do so, a relatively small share of the population, drive a disproportionate amount of traffic to partisan outlets and also appear to participate more in politics.
- Even if most Americans do not exist in online echo chambers, they are subject to the political influence of those who do.

4. Discussion

a. Implications

- Consistent with previous findings of a relative lack of political interest in the population.
- A complement to studies on opinion leaders: Opinion leaders are likely to rely on much more ideologically extreme information sources to shape their attitudes and behaviors than the rest of the public.
- Consistent with traditional communication research, people are satisfied with information in front of them, convenient to reach.
- Compared to previous studies' similar findings, the methods used in this study, with passive metering data and machine learning improve ecological validity.
- Large, mainstream online intermediaries provide shared mediated experiences and access to diverse perspectives.

b. Limitations

c. Future Directions

- Can do successive panel waves to track survey respondents' attitudes and news recall for more in-depth investigation of how people respond to news consumption.
- Can further study the consequences and determinants of media choice. For example, how social media influences information consumption; how their media consumption influences people's attitudes, knowledge, and political behavior...
- More passive metering data can support longitudinal research and exploration of over-time dynamics. For example, how people's information-seeking behaviors and habits change.

d. ...

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Response Letter (~600 words)

- Your assessment of the study
- Weaknesses
- Other notes

This study used a computational method to analyze large-scale data to answer a classical question: whether the internet facilitates echo chambers in political news consumption. The findings of this study are somewhat counterintuitive to me, as they show information exposure polarization is not severe as we might have imagined. Instead, the political media diets of most people are relatively moderate, and there is substantial overlap between Democrats and Republicans.

The study is methodologically robust and rigorous, as supported by the rationale provided by the author. The author devoted a substantial portion of the paper to discussing methodological challenges, reviewing the methods used by previous studies, and explaining the rationale for methods used in this study. The paper outlined the methods and limitations of previous studies investigating similar research questions, such as the lack of external validity in experiments, social desirability bias in self-report surveys, and the small sample sizes and lack of representativeness in in-depth interviews. This reflection on the limitations of other methods provides a rationale for using large-scale data and passive metering data, which increases generalizability through scale while also offering individual-level tracking rather than aggregated evidence. I am not sure whether this is due to disciplinary differences, but in communication research, such an extensive methodology-focused review does not seem very common.

I also find the analysis and results sections compelling. Rather than following a predefined sequence for hypothesis testing, the results are organized in an exploratory and inductive way. I like that the researcher allows the findings from earlier analyses to guide subsequent analytical steps and transition across different dimensions of analysis. The author first focused on individual-level summaries of media diets and then moved to website-level summaries to provide further and more consistent evidence. Also, after identifying a small proportion of individuals with highly polarized media diets, he further linked the data to voter turnout information from TargetSmart, offering preliminary evidence of how this subgroup's slanted media consumption may influence democratic discourse and the electoral process. In addition, most analyses rely on relatively simple statistical techniques, such as descriptive summaries, distributional analyses, and simple linear regression. These analyses complement and reinforce one another effectively, collectively supporting the study's overall conclusions.

Concerning methodological weaknesses, every method has limitations, but what stood out to me is that the researcher was transparent and considerate every time he made discretionary decisions about data preprocessing and analysis. One challenge of the consumption data obtained through passive metering techniques is that the data are really comprehensive and require new methods for extracting meaningful variables. The researcher used alignment scores developed by previous research, as well as a self-trained classifier, to code and classify the raw data. It is noteworthy that the author further examined different measurements and preprocessing decisions may lead to

different results. For example, results may differ if the measurement of media diet is based on the duration of web visits rather than visit number, or if the duplicated visits are excluded. These analyses are thoroughly documented in the supplementary materials, demonstrating that the author made careful decisions at each step. This comprehensive consideration and transparent documentation benefit not only ethical standards, but also reproducibility.

Regarding the fact that the data used in this study were collected in 2015 and 2016, I think the results may not fully apply to today's media environment. Currently, how people consume news articles and the pathways through which they encounter information have evolved substantially. In the context of when this study was conducted, people still relied on web portals, mainstream news sites, and links shared on social media to access news. However, today, both the modality and content of news have evolved driven by platform design and affordances. Do people today still read news articles, or are they primarily exposed to information from influencers or comment sections? It seems that people may rely less on mainstream news sites and news aggregators, which were found in this study to be key drivers of a more diverse, moderate, and less polarized news exposure. In this sense, it would be worthwhile to conduct a similar study in today's internet environment.